

THE PLEDGE NCP patriarch Sharad Pawar meets party workers in Mumbai, Jul. 5

held parallel shows of strength. Ajit's rally saw 32 MLAs in attendance, while his uncle could muster the support of only 18 (by night, the numbers had dwindled to 13, say reports). Ajit's aides claim they have the support of over 40 MLAs (the two-thirds mark to circumvent the anti-defection statutes is 36). The picture may become clearer by the monsoon session of the state legislature, which is scheduled for later in July, till which time both factions will surely be working to corral as many legislators as they can.

The NCP factions have also launched action against each other. The Sharad Pawar group has filed disqualification petitions with assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar against the nine newly-minted ministers; senior leaders Praful Patel and Sunil Tatkare have been removed from the party for anti-party activities. The party may move disqualification petitions against them.

The Ajit camp has countered with disqualification petitions of its own against Jayant Patil and Jitendra Awhad, the new state president and legislative party leader in the assembly (replacing Ajit), respectively. The rival camp has also appointed Tatkare as the state unit chief in Patil's place. After the initial attempts at staying civil, now even Pawar Sr is fair game. Ajit and his men have launched personal attacks against the NCP patriarch, claiming the latter had his lines open with the BJP in the past and, at 82, is well past his prime and should retire.

Pawar Sr, however, has the reputation of a "fighter", which he had proved again in the 2019 assembly election, when all seemed lost for the Congress and the NCP. His loyalists hope that Pawar, who has again hit the ground running, will repeat this feat. However, sceptics raise the age issue, and this time even diehard loyalists such as Praful Patel and Chhagan Bhujbal are not by his side. On July 3, Guru Purnima day, Pawar Sr visited the memorial of his political mentor and former deputy prime minister Yashwantrao Chavan at Karad in Satara district. Speaking to the crowds later, Pawar promised to punish the forces that had split the party and "show them their place".

INNER TURMOIL

The developments have also led to ripples within the state BJP. Fadnavis, the Maharashtra chief minister from 2014-19, had already been chafing at having to play second fiddle to Shinde. He will now have to share space with another deputy CM and there is already speculation that he may be shifted to New Delhi in the proposed expansion of the Union cabinet. Though the iron-like grip of the leadership will keep dissidence in check, there is resentment in the BJP over loyalists being persistently ignored in favour of newcomers and the party's allies. Compared to the Shinde and Ajit factions, the BJP has the lowest MLA-to-minister ratio in the state cabinet. Maharashtra can have a maximum of 43 ministers; with the nine NCP leaders, the number is now up to 29. Out of them, only nine are from the BJP, apart from Fadnavis.

The NCP's entry will create other issues too. The BJP was grooming a second generation of leaders to take on NCP satraps like Ajit, many of them from the Other Backward Classes (OBC), an attempt to undercut the NCP, which is seen as a Maratha-dominated party. Gopichand Padalkar, who belongs to the Dhangar (shepherd) caste, the second-largest caste cluster after the dominant Maratha community, was seen as a challenger to Ajit from the Baramati assembly segment. The fate of this social engineering experiment may be in a limbo now.

Also, senior BJP leaders like former minister Pankaja Munde, whose estranged cousin and political rival Dhananjay Munde has taken oath with Ajit, may feel they have been pushed further into a corner. The distribution of seats between the three new allies—Shinde's Sena faction, the BJP and Ajit's NCP cohorts is likely to be a logistical nightmare.

BJP old-timers wonder about the toll this is taking on the party. "The *karyakarta* struggles with the party to win elections, but if we have to break other parties to retain power, governance and organisation will pay a price. We have seen it in Karnataka and other states," notes a party insider. Others point to the sorry figure BJP leaders like Kirit Somaiya are cutting in the present scenario. The former Mumbai Northeast MP had launched a series of exposes against NCP legislator Hassan Mushrif and his aides in a money-laundering case. Before that, he had Bhujbal in the cross-hairs. In a recent video, Somaiya had exulted that the Enforcement Directorate (ED) investigations were almost over and that Mushrif would soon be behind bars. Now Mushrif has a cabinet spot, and that too facilitated by the BJP.

Incidentally, just last month, Prime Minister Narendra Modi too had accused the NCP of large-scale corruption in irrigation projects in Maharashtra. Fingers had been pointed at Ajit, who was water resources minister in 2009 and also Tatkare, who succeeded him. Tatkare's daughter Aditi was sworn in as a minister with Ajit.